Inheriting the Metropolis: Race, Mobility, and Belonging from James Baldwin's *Another Country* to Teju Cole's *Open City*

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1. Introduction:

As Teju Cole spent several summers in Leukerbad between 2014 and 2019, he deliberately followed a path James Baldwin had taken more than sixty years earlier. At the time, Baldwin was one of the first Black people to live in such a small Swiss village, an experience that inspired his essay "*Stranger in the Village"*. Cole's return to the same Swiss village was more than a literary homage: it positioned Baldwin as an intellectual predecessor whose reflections on race, belonging, and Europe remained central to Cole's own work (Cole, "Black Body"). In that sense, in her essay examining the affiliative relationship between James Baldwin and Teju Cole, Monika Gehlawat draws on Edward Said's concept of affiliation to argue that Baldwin functions as an intellectual predecessor whom Cole consciously adopts and reinterprets. For Cole, Baldwin embodies the Black subject who negotiates a position between Europe and America while confronting questions of race, belonging, and cultural identity (Gehlawat 49–55).

Although both writers are American, they occupy different historical and diasporic positions. Baldwin writes from the perspective of an African American subject whose relationship to Africa is mediated by the direct history of slavery and racial segregation in a pre-Civil Rights Act America. While Cole's fiction, by contrast, focuses on an American protagonist whose Nigerian heritage and transnational mobility complicate a fixed understanding of Black identity. This difference helps explain why *Open City* (2011) engages more easily with Afropolitanism than *Another Country* (1962), also a concept that did not exist at the time Baldwin wrote. The comparison between Baldwin and Cole is therefore not intended to collapse their historical experiences into a single model of Black identity. Rather, it examines how two different moments in Black Atlantic history imagine race, mobility, and urban belonging mainly through the city of New York.

This essay examines the literary heritage linking *Another Country* and *Open City* by asking how Teju Cole inherits, transforms, and at times departs from James Baldwin's representation of race, urban modernity, and belonging across two different historical moments. By comparing Baldwin's openly segregated New York with Cole's apparently cosmopolitan metropolis, this essay argues that racial experience has not disappeared but has been transformed from visible urban division into subtler forms of memory, mobility, and contested belonging. Drawing on Berman's account of modernity, Gilroy's conception of the Black Atlantic, social urban theory of Lefebvre and debates surrounding Afropolitanism, the essay first establishes its theoretical framework before analyzing *Another Country* and *Open City*.

As a conclusion, I will argue that Baldwin anticipates some of the questions that Afropolitanism later addresses—mobility, multiple belongings, and identity beyond the nation—without sharing the historical conditions from which Afropolitanism emerges. In a certain way, we will see how he wanted to see a different version of America beyond racism, and we will finally go back to an article from Cole about Baldwin and how they differ in their vision of being African writers in the world. I will then conclude with an epilogue that will tell you why I found this historical evolution especially interesting.

1.1 Theoretical Framework

> To be modern is to find ourselves in an environment that promises us adventure, power, joy, growth, transformation of ourselves and the world — and, at the same time, that threatens to destroy everything we have, everything we know, everything we are.
> *(*Berman 15)

This essay approaches both *Another Country* and *Open City* through the city as a space of modern experience and as medium for Afropolitan conceptions. Marshall Berman, an urban theorist, defines modernity as a contradictory condition that simultaneously promises transformation and threatens instability. The metropolis therefore becomes the privileged site where identities are continuously reshaped through encounters, mobility, and conflict (Berman 15).
In that sense, for Berman, New York works as a symbolic landscape where contradicting identities and symbols coexist:

> The cumulative impact of all this is that the New Yorker finds himself in the midst of a Baudelairean forest of symbols… But they also make it a dangerous place, because its symbols and symbolisms are endlessly fighting each other for sun and light, working to kill each other off, melting each other along with themselves into air. (Berman 289)

In both novels, characters are trying to find meanings and establish a stronger sense of identities, for example as we will see Julius in *Open City* reads monuments, statues, buildings, architecture as a palimpsest where competing meaning and identities coexist and emerge.

Whereas Berman explains the modern metropolis through contradicting symbols, Paul Gilroy shifts attention towards the specific experience of the Black Atlantic, which explains the experience of the African voices through a global migration movement, encompassing the slave trade, African American experience, and diasporic voices. For Gilroy the Atlantic is "one single, complex unit of analysis…that produced an explicitly transnational and intercultural perspective" (15). It is a framework that enables us here to put both Baldwin's novel and Cole's novel on the same plane.
Rather than understanding identity as rooted in a single nation, Gilroy argues that Black identity is produced through movement, migration, and cultural exchange across the Atlantic. Gilroy describes his own method as "dealing equally with the significance of roots and routes" (190), meaning that the black identity is important as a passage, a mediation on where it is from and where it is going. For example, in both novels a transatlantic movement is happening: in *Open City* Julius, a Nigerian American, is traveling in Europe (80) or in *Another Country* Ida, an African American girl, is having a relationship with an Italian-American guy and dreams about moving to Europe (343). This shows how an Atlantic identity can be formed, depending on mobility, class or on the historical period which constrains the novels' characters.

As noted in the introduction, it is important not only to explain why a comparison between Baldwin and Cole is possible, but also to situate this literary genealogy within the broader framework of Afropolitanism. In her influential essay *Bye-Bye Barbar*, Taiye Selasi introduces Afropolitanism as a way of describing a generation of Africans whose identities are shaped by mobility, multiple belongings, and transnational experience. As she writes, "Like so many African young people working and living in cities around the globe, they belong to no single geography, but feel at home in many" (528). Identity for her is therefore produced through movement, multiple belongings and political independence:

> Ultimately, the Afropolitan must form an identity along three dimensions: national, racial, cultural—with subtle tensions in between… The way we see our race… is a question of politics, rather than pigment… Finally, how we conceive of race will accord with where we locate ourselves in the history that produced 'blackness'… (Selasi 530)

Although Selasi's formulation has become influential, it has also attracted criticism. Emma Dabiri argues that Afropolitanism risks celebrating the mobility of a relatively privileged African elite while overlooking broader histories of inequality and structural racism (Dabiri 105). Rather than adopting Selasi uncritically, this essay uses Afropolitanism as a useful descriptive concept while remaining attentive to its limitations.

Bringing James Baldwin and Teju Cole into dialogue is not self-evident. Baldwin writes from the perspective of an African American intellectual shaped by segregation and the Civil Rights era, whereas Cole belongs to a later generation whose work reflects globalization, migration, and diasporic mobility. Yet Cole explicitly identifies Baldwin as an intellectual predecessor, suggesting a literary genealogy that extends beyond their different historical contexts.

2. The Origins of *Another Country*

> "This world is white no longer, and it will never be white again."
> (Baldwin, *Notes* 179)

This sentence appears at the end of *Notes of a Native Son* and serves as a good introduction into *Another Country*. Baldwin's essays argue that racial categories inherited from American history can no longer explain the changing social world of the postwar period. Another Country extends this project into fiction by imagining interracial encounters through the space of New York.
Throughout *Notes of a Native Son*, Baldwin repeatedly returns to the relationship between history and identity. His travels through Europe do not free him from the legacy of American racism; instead, they reveal how deeply racial history continues to shape both Black and white Americans. Rather than imagining Black and white Americans as separate communities, Baldwin argues that "no other people has ever been so deeply involved in the lives of black men, and vice versa" (179). For Baldwin, this interconnection means that neither Black nor white Americans can escape the past that has shaped their relationship. This explains for him why "[p]eople are trapped in history and history is trapped in them" (167).

In that sense, in *Another Country*, Baldwin presents New York as a city in which Black and white Americans increasingly occupy shared urban spaces during the social transformations of the late 1950s and early 1960s. Rather than depicting racial integration as an accomplished reality, Baldwin portrays interracial encounters as unstable and often conflictual. The metropolis becomes a site where characters negotiate identity, belonging, desire, and exclusion. Baldwin's vision suggests that the proximity created by urban modernity offers the possibility of new forms of interracial encounters, even if these possibilities are continually frustrated by the persistence of structural racism and deeply embedded social prejudices. Consequently, New York functions not merely as the setting of the novel but as the social space in which the contradictions of American modernity are made visible.

2.1 The Metropolis in *Another Country*

"Entirely alone, and dying of it, he was part of an unprecedented multitude…" (*Another Country* 14)

In the first part of the book we follow Rufus, an African American musician who is searching for himself in the city. Something that we will see later is close to the "flânerie" of Julius. Here "flânerie" is taken from the French and means to stroll aimlessly in a city. But in the novel Rufus almost functions as an "anti-flâneur", as he strolls through the metropolis but is hindered and overwhelmed by it (14–20).

Indeed, in the novel, Rufus cannot walk anonymously. His movements through the city are constantly interpreted through the lens of race. Reflecting on his relationship with Leona, a white southern girl, Rufus realizes that "No one dared to look at Vivaldo, out with any girl whatever, the way they looked at Rufus now; nor would they ever look at the girl the way they looked at Leona… This was because Vivaldo was white" (39). Later in the novel, Baldwin extends this logic to Vivaldo (a white Italian American) himself. As his relationship with Ida (Rufus's sister) develops, he gradually becomes aware of his own whiteness through the hostile and suspicious glances directed at the interracial couple. Baldwin thus shows that walking through New York is never a neutral activity but one structured by racial visibility: "here were the black-and-white couples, defiantly white, flamboyantly black; and the Italians watched them, hating them…" (292). Vivaldo thus discovers his own whiteness by being confronted with the glances of people judging him for being with a black girl. Later in the novel, Eric characterizes New York as "a city without oases, run entirely, and forever, for money" (311). In that sense, the metropolis provides no respite from the social gaze that constantly shapes the characters' movements.

The changing social geography of New York before the Civil Rights Act brings Black and white characters into closer proximity, creating new possibilities for interracial relationships. But at the same time, those relationships remain subject to racial hierarchies reproduced within the urban space. The social gaze extends beyond the streets into the supposedly private spaces of everyday life. As Ida's relationship with Vivaldo develops, even the apartment building becomes a site of racial surveillance. The narrator observes that "the landlord and the neighbors and the cop on the corner disapproved of Ida's presence" (276). Rather than functioning as a private refuge from the public sphere, the domestic space reinforces the racial hierarchies that organize the city. As Lefebvre argues, "(Social) space is a (social) product" (26). The apartment building therefore becomes more than a physical setting: it is a space in which landlords, neighbors, and even the police reproduce racial boundaries and regulate interracial intimacy. Lefebvre's concept of the social production of space provides here a useful framework for understanding Baldwin's representation of New York.

Yet occupying the same urban spaces does not mean that characters experience the city in the same way. In the fourth chapter of the second book, Ida, who has started a singing career, brings Cass, a white woman friend, to a club attended by the agent with whom she is having an affair. There Ida confronts Cass about what she knows about being black: "there's no way in the world for you to find out what it's like to be a black girl in this world" (341). Even if both women share a friendship and live in the same place, they still don't understand each other. Also for Ida the city feels like a prison: "wouldn't you hate all white people if they kept you in a prison here?" (343), then she starts to dream of moving to another country with Vivaldo (343). These reflections anticipate later Afropolitan concerns about mobility, belonging, and the search for identities beyond the confines of a single nation.

At the end of the book, Eric's lover, Yves, finally arrives in New York. As his plane approaches the city, he expects to see one of its defining symbols, the Statue of Liberty (422). His first impression is therefore shaped by an image rather than by the people who inhabit the city. Baldwin further notes that, at this moment, "the people did not exist" for him (422). As Marshall Berman argues, modern cities are "planned

specifically as symbolic expressions of modernity" (289). New York thus appears not only as a lived space but also as a symbolic landscape onto which meanings of freedom, modernity, and national identity are projected.

Baldwin's New York therefore emerges as both a lived and a symbolic space, where modernity, racial history, and mobility intersect. The city's monuments and streets become sites onto which competing meanings of identity and belonging are projected. This understanding of the metropolis provides an important point of departure for *Open City*, where many of these questions reappear within the context of globalization and contemporary diasporic experience.

3. The Metropolis in *Open City*

> Modernists today no longer insist, as the modernists of yesterday so often did, that we must cease to be Jewish, or black, or Italian, or anything, in order to be modern... ethnic identity —not only one's own but everyone's —was essential to the depth and fullness of self that modern life opens up and promises to all (Berman 333)

Open City returns to many of the questions Baldwin raises about New York before the Civil Rights Act.

Through Julius's walks, the globalized metropolis becomes a space in which past and present constantly overlap rather than replace one another. At the beginning of the novel, Julius walks through a rainy New York and observes: "the intensity of the rain blurred my sight, a phenomenon I had noticed before only with snowstorms… Manhattan looked just then like it must have in the 1920s or even… much further in the past" (36). This observation recalls the idea of the urban palimpsest, something being erased and rewritten on. Here Cole reflects on what New York was once, and how it is now conversing with its past. Unlike the characters in *Another Country*, whose movements are constrained by racial surveillance, Julius moves through the city with a relative freedom that allows him to perceive those layered histories. We can connect that to Berman where he states that modernity is a condition in which people continuously struggle to find a sense of belonging in an ever-changing urban world. As he writes, "we and those who come after us will go on fighting to make ourselves at home in this world, even as the homes we have made, the modern street, the modern spirit, go on melting into air" (348). In this respect, Berman's understanding of modernity also resonates with Afropolitan writing, in which identity is continually reconstructed through mobility, memory, and the changing layers of the metropolis.

This movement, however, is not straightforward. At the beginning of the novel, when Julius takes a taxi through New York, he enters it abruptly without greeting the driver. He tries to connect with him later on, calling him "brother". But the driver is angry at the way Julius came in the taxi and tells him: "I'm African just like you" (40). The driver subsequently takes him to the wrong destination. Julius thinks: "Anger had welled up within me, unhinging me, the anger of a shattered repose" (41).
At the end of the scene, Julius's contemplation is broken by the whole situation, and he ultimately ends the encounter by paying the fare and leaving, illustrating how his social position allows him to withdraw from a shared experience that the taxi driver continues to inhabit. This type of encounter sits differently from the social space of *Another Country*, where money or one's social class cannot extract you from such a situation. Dabiri's critique of Afropolitanism is useful here. She argues that "While Afropolitanism may go some way in redressing the balance concerning Africans speaking for themselves, the problem lies in the fact that we still do not hear the narratives of Africans who are not privileged" (105). Julius's refusal to engage with the taxi driver suggests that shared African origins do not automatically produce solidarity. Instead, their encounter is mediated by differences in class, mobility, and social privilege.

Another point of comparison with Another Country concerns competing models of cosmopolitan belonging. When Julius meets Farouq and Khalil in a café in Brussels, their conversation turns to communitarianism, multiculturalism, and the question of what binds communities together. Khalil criticizes communitarianism, arguing that it gives "unfair leverage to minority interests" and is "logically flawed" because its categories—race, language, religion, ethnicity, and tribe—do not align neatly (118). His position nevertheless places greater emphasis on historically grounded communal identities than Julius's cosmopolitan detachment. Julius, by contrast, does not fully engage in the discussion: "He continued in this vein for a few minutes, and I lost the thread of his argument, but I didn't ask Farouq to translate. I drank my beer" (118).

Khalil's insistence on the importance of historically grounded communities recalls Gilroy's rejection of unitary conceptions of Black identity. Gilroy argues that "the authoritarian tendencies of those who would police black cultural expression in the name of their own particular history or priorities are rightly repudiated" (32). Gilroy's conception of diaspora therefore offers an alternative to both Khalil's emphasis on communal identity and Julius's cosmopolitan detachment, suggesting that collective identities should remain open, relational, and internally diverse. Significantly, Julius asks Farouq what "communitarian" means, suggesting his distance from the very vocabulary through which collective belonging is being debated. Rather than taking a clear position, he remains an observer throughout the discussion.
Unlike Baldwin's characters, who are compelled to negotiate race through immediate social conflict, Julius repeatedly encounters opportunities to define what cosmopolitan or Afropolitan belonging might mean, yet he consistently refuses to commit himself to any shared or stable identity. This ambiguity complicates any straightforward reading of him as an Afropolitan subject.

Towards the end of the novel, Julius experiences something close to what Berman describes as the symbolic interpretation of the city (289). As he walks toward Chinatown, Julius reflects on the neighborhood and notes: "Little signs remained of what the neighborhood had been in the 1800s…" before noticing the statue of Lin Zexu, a historical figure associated with resistance to the British during the Opium Wars (189). This passage again suggests that the modern city is made of overlapping historical layers rather than one uniform present. In his observation of the neighborhood, as is consistently the case in the novel, the past suffuses the present: colonial histories clash with a newly constructed momentous and contemporary New York landscape. This echoes Baldwin's symbolic New York but expands it globally. Even though the narrator points to the fact that he is one of the few non-East Asian people in Chinatown, this neighborhood pushes him to reflect on his own identity: as the sound of a marching band reminds him of a song he had heard while being in the Nigerian military school (192). Chinatown therefore becomes more than an ethnic enclave; it becomes a site where different histories, memories, and identities intersect. Rather than presenting identity as fixed or rooted in a single place, Cole depicts New York as a city in which global histories continually overlap, reinforcing the novel's vision of the metropolis as an open and layered space.

4. Conclusion

Even though *Another Country* and *Open City* are set almost 60 years apart, they both imagine New York as a space where identities, race and belonging are blending. Cole inherits the questions Baldwin was trying to answer about New York, at a time when the Civil Rights Act hadn't been enacted yet. Was whiteness about to be over with, meaning racial categories as they stood until then? Baldwin wrote about an emerging new society, where new and old ways of perceiving the world and interracial relationships were clashing. Cole takes up these questions by imagining the colonial past of New York and confronting it with the contemporary New York space. The old structures of visible segregation that characterize *Another Country* are disappearing under more subtle forms of remembrance, different types of mobility and new types of belonging. Cole does not see New York as an absolute prison anymore, where the black characters are guarded by the white worldview, but contemplates other forms of belonging and blending in the metropolis. However, as we have seen with Dabiri, this vision doesn't apply to everyone, and might be limited to a small class of mobile and privileged individuals, therefore limiting the Afropolitan experience. This limitation can also be understood through Berman's and Cole's conception of the modern metropolis. Both depict the city as a space where multiple histories and experiences collapse into one another, making it impossible to arrive at a single or definitive experience of New York.

In that sense, a few things have changed between 1962 and 2011; both visions of the city contain their characters in a fixed state of things, withholding any real possibility of emancipation from individualism and the modern condition. Baldwin anticipates Afropolitanism, but is not Afropolitan, as he also does not see racial categorization disappearing anytime soon in the novel. As we saw throughout this analysis, though several concerns presented by Baldwin later became central to Afropolitan thought: mobility, multiple belonging, and identities irreducible to classic national categories, they are not yet brought to a definite conclusion or emancipation. Yet these similarities should not obscure the different historical conditions under which Baldwin and Cole write. Baldwin's characters remain fundamentally shaped by segregation and the legacy of slavery, whereas Cole's Julius inhabits a globalized world in which mobility itself becomes a source of ambiguity rather than liberation.

Consequently, the metropolis fulfills different functions in the two novels. In *Another Country*, New York still shows the racial tension in a pre-Civil Rights Act America, where even interracial proximity fails to overcome structural racism. In *Open City,* the city is more like a cosmopolitan palimpsest shaped by colonial

memories, identity politics and diasporic tension. As we saw, Julius enjoys new ways of mobility that Rufus never could have dreamt of, but this freedom is also limited by a reluctance to commit himself to any collective identity.
Cole therefore inherits Baldwin's questions rather than his answers. The dialogue between the two novels reveals not the disappearance of race but the changing forms through which Black identity continues to be negotiated across the modern metropolis.

5. Epilogue:

A point that marked me, and was the origin for this essay, was the moment when Julius goes to Carnegie Hall to experience one of Mahler's symphonies. He actually states that "Mahler's music is not white, or black, not old or young, and whether it is even specifically human, rather than in accord with more universal vibrations, is open to question" (252). This is something that Baldwin would have never said at the time. He indeed talks about this white culture in *Notes of a Native Son:*

> These were not really my creations, they did not contain my history; I might search in them in vain forever for any reflection of myself. I was an interloper; this was not my heritage. (Baldwin, *Notes* 7)
>
> These people cannot be, from the point of view of power, strangers anywhere in the world; they have made the modern world, in effect, even if they do not know it. The most illiterate among them is related, in a way that I am not, to Dante, Shakespeare, Michelangelo, Aeschylus, Da Vinci, Rembrandt, and Racine; the cathedral at Chartres says something to them which it cannot say to me, as indeed would New York's Empire State Building, should anyone here ever see it. Out of their hymns and dances come Beethoven and Bach. Go back a few centuries and they are in their full glory—but I am in Africa, watching the conquerors arrive. (Baldwin, *Notes* 169)

In that sense, it is where both writers differ, but Baldwin was probably dreaming about something different and would have loved to be part of it like Julius. Cole's reply to Baldwin:

> This is where I part ways with Baldwin. I disagree not with his particular sorrow but with the self-abnegation that pinned him to it. Bach, so profoundly human, is my heritage. I am not an interloper when I look at a Rembrandt portrait. (Cole, "Black Body")

For me, choosing Baldwin's novel was also a way to show how he tried to breach that gap between the old racist world and the new coming Afropolitan world, a very avant-garde thing to do at the time representing the emerging interactions of the early 60s, before Teju Cole and the Afropolitans. Being myself from Wallis, this resonates also with me, imagining Baldwin in Leukerbad and seeing how racism was present at the time in my canton of birth.

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Claude AI was used to organize the numerous notes I had taken while reading the primary and secondary sources, it helped me locate passages more efficiently during the writing process, and to get feedback on the organization of the essay and the development of the argument.
ChatGPT was used for proofreading, language correction, feedback on structure, and MLA formatting. All primary and secondary sources cited in this essay were read and consulted by me, and the interpretation of the texts, the development of the argument, the analysis, and the conclusions presented in this essay are entirely my own.